

Benjamin Wittenbrink

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EDUCATION

Massachusetts Institute of Technology <i>Ph.D., Economics</i> (GPA: 5.0/5.0) Fields (expected): Industrial Organization, Public Finance, Political Economy	Cambridge, MA 2024 –
Stanford University <i>M.S., Computer Science</i> , concentration in Artificial Intelligence (GPA: 4.00/4.00) <i>B.A. with Honors, Economics & B.S., Mathematics</i> (GPA: 3.99/4.00)	Stanford, CA 2017 – 2023

WORKING PAPERS

- “Cataloging Growth: A Re-Evaluation of 1900–1990” (with Verónica Bäcker-Peral), 2026.
- “The Minimum Wage and Social Security Disability Insurance” (with Mark Duggan and Gopi Goda), 2021.

PUBLICATIONS

- “The Effect of Deactivating Facebook and Instagram on Users’ Emotional State” (with Hunt Allcott, Matthew Gentzkow, et al.). *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, forthcoming (NBER WP #33697).
- “The Effects of Political Advertising on Facebook and Instagram before the 2020 US Election” (with Hunt Allcott, Matthew Gentzkow, Ro’ee Levy, et al.). *Nature Human Behaviour*, 10, 2026 (NBER WP #33818).
- “The Effects of Facebook and Instagram on the 2020 Election: A Deactivation Experiment” (with Hunt Allcott, Matthew Gentzkow, et al.). *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 121(21), May 2024.
- “Single-Trial Visually Evoked Potentials Predict Both Individual Choice and Market Outcomes” (with John Veillette, Shannon Heald, Katherine Reis, and Howard Nusbaum). *Scientific Reports*, 13(1), 2023.
- “Analyzing Candidates’ Ideological Messaging Throughout the Electoral System”. *Stanford Department of Economics Honors Thesis*, 2022.

RESEARCH AND WORK EXPERIENCE

MIT Dept. of Economics <i>Research Assistant for Michael Whinston</i>	Cambridge, MA 2026 –
MIT Dept. of Economics <i>Research Assistant for Tobias Salz</i>	Cambridge, MA 2025 –
QuantCo <i>Quantitative Researcher & Machine Learning Engineer</i>	San Francisco, CA 2023 – 2024
Stanford Dept. of Economics <i>Research Assistant for Matthew Gentzkow</i>	Stanford, CA 2022 – 2023
QuantCo <i>Quantitative Research & Data Science Intern</i>	Zürich, CH 2019, 2020-2021
New York Federal Reserve <i>Summer Analyst, Research & Statistics</i>	New York, NY 2020
Stanford Institute of Economic Policy <i>Undergraduate Research Assistant for Mark Duggan and Gopi Goda</i>	Stanford, CA 2018 – 2020
Stanford & University of Chicago <i>Undergraduate Research Assistant for Howard Nusbaum, John List, Rebecca Diamond, Jonathan Rodden</i>	Stanford, CA & Chicago, IL 2018 – 2019

HONORS AND AWARDS

Castle Krob Fellowship in Economics, MIT	2024 – 2026
George & Obie Shultz Fund Grant, MIT	2025, 2026
PyTorch Geometric Featured Project, Stanford CS 224W: Machine Learning with Graphs	2023
Anna Laura Myers Prize for Outstanding Honors Thesis, Stanford Economics	2022
Best Project (Audience Selection), Stanford CS 224N: NLP with Deep Learning	2022

Best Data Visualization Article , <i>Stanford Daily</i> Volume 257	2020
First Place , <i>SIEPR Policy Hackathon</i>	2019

PH.D. COURSEWORK

Massachusetts Institute of Technology	Cambridge, MA
Microeconomics I, II, III, IV	2024 – 2025
Econometrics I, II, III, IV	
Macroeconomics I, II	
Industrial Organization I (theory), III (empirical)	
Public Economics I, II	
International Trade I, II (spatial)	
Labor Economics	
Algorithms & Behavioral Science	
Political Economy of Democracies (Harvard)	
Stanford University	Stanford, CA
Political Economy I	2019 – 2023
Intermediate Econometrics II	
Machine Learning & Causal Inference	
Simplicity and Complexity in Economic Theory	
Macroeconomics I	

SELECTED COURSE PROJECTS

“Redistribution with Prices, Rationing, and Queuing,” 2023.

“Spotify Graph Neural Recommender Systems,” 2023.

“An NLP Approach to Understanding Patent Acceptance Criteria,” 2022.

“Predicting Maternal and Infant Health Outcomes in Western Africa using Satellite Images,” 2022.

“Using Images to Predict Work-from-Home Shocks,” 2022.

“Predicting Kickstarter Project Success with Machine Learning,” 2021.

SKILLS

Programming: Python, R, SQL, C++, C, Julia, Stata, Java

Computer (other): Git, $\LaTeX$, AWS, GCP, Azure, PyTorch, TensorFlow

Languages: English (native); German (professional proficiency)

Standardized Tests: GRE: Math (170/170), Verbal (168/170), Writing (6.0/6.0)